FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

We knew we were on to something good from our first outing. It was originally conceived as a one-off to culminate the magazine's silver jubilee celebrations in October 2001, but just before that, there came the world-changing event of 9/11. This was followed by the dramatic attack by Pakistani terrorists on India's Parliament on December 13. Our first Conclave was conducted in January 2002 in the shadow of these two unforgettable events. It turned out to be the perfect platform to assess and discuss the state of the world with brilliant minds from around the globe in a way that went beyond conventional journalism. As we complete 20 eventful editions of the Conclave this March, we can look back with pride and satisfaction at what has almost been an almanac of our times.

Each phase of the Conclave caught something essential about critical cusp moments in history—from the 'securitisation' of international affairs in that first decade, to the popular protests that kicked off the next one, to the unlikely blend of conviction and uncertainty we inhabit in the post-Covid years. On this subsoil sprouted the transformational moments of global and local politics. Even the personages who lit up our stage over the years seem like a roll-call from the many acts of a great theatrical play: Al Gore in 2002, A.B. Vajpayee, Sonia Gandhi, Pervez Musharraf in a couple of stormy and riveting sessions, the Clintons in their individual avatars at separate points, Colin Powell, Hamid Karzai, Nelson Mandela, Mohammed Khatami, Sarah Palin, Benazir Bhutto, historian Francis Fukuyama, scientist Dr J. Craig Venter, chess grandmaster Garry Kasparov, the prescient economist Nouriel Roubini, director James Cameron, authors Salman Rushdie, Niall Ferguson, Yuval Noah Harari, Amitav Ghosh and a roster of Indian names of the highest calibre. Among those luminaries, one name has figured six times. Narendra Damodardas Modi—in different stages of his rise—from his earlier avatar as Gujarat chief minister to his days of total spectrum dominance over India's political landscape, undimmed for a decade. His personage is, in a way, interlaced with how our themes have evolved.



In 2002, we chose a theme that reflected the mood of the moment—India Tomorrow: Opportunities and Threats. Two years later, still at the dawn of a new epoch, we put an interesting thought out—Building an Indian Century. As I said in my opening remarks, "We knew the idea was aspirational but worth testing." We can now say, "With over a fifth of the 21st century gone, The Giant Has Arrived. It is India's Moment." We as a nation have fulfilled that promise to a substantial degree. Our economy, the fifth largest globally, is borne aloft by an under-35 demographic of 1 billion that's being transformed up and down the pyramid by digitisation. Our signature as a powerful presence in the world is visible everywhere, from geopolitics to entertainment. That gave us the theme for 2023—The India Moment. At the heart of it, I spot a key trend: the passage of India from the days of a '*chalta hai*' attitude to a 'Can Do/Doing/Done' spirit.

People on all sides of our noisy polity will agree on one point: Prime Minister Modi exemplifies this restlessness for change. As he said in his keynote address, "The most special thing about the India Moment is that promise is coupled with performance." He buttressed his point with a listicle of accomplishments during the first 75 days (till March 19) of 2023. There was hard infrastructure: airports, expressways, brand-new trains, metro lines, indigenous helicopters, 80 million new tap water connections. There were signs of power in the world, like Air India placing the highest aviation order of all time. And powerful ideas were brought to fruition, like the E-20 fuel, the International Solar Alliance and the push India is giving to healthy millet cereals. The two Oscars India has won rounded off the showcasing of India's soft power, symbolised in another way by the return of cheetahs to this land.

One of the reasons the Conclave has been a favourite event on my calendar is the cumulative energy and spark brought by a variety of brilliant speakers. If PM Modi only spoke of politics tangentially, Union home minister Amit Shah took the topic head-on while laying out the growth path he envisages for the BJP, alongside his own ministry's achievements in the area of internal security. Rebutting criticism of the perceived overreach of central investigative agencies like the CBI and ED, he said anyone who thinks such action is unfair is free to go to the courts.

That also gestured at another rich vein touched by the Conclave. We usually have a mix of the ruling party and opposition politicians, global statesmen, scientists, corporate heads, intellectuals and rising stars from the entertainment and sports world lighting up proceedings. This time, a solid judiciary contingent added to the discussions' depth. Chief Justice D.Y. Chandrachud did the unprecedented by having a scintillating live interaction without any prepared speech. On the perceived conflict between the executive and judiciary, he followed the lead of Union law minister Kiren Rijiju, who had spoken earlier in the day, saying it was perhaps a difference of perception that could be dealt with "a sense of robust constitutional statesmanship".

Between sessions by foreign minister S. Jaishankar, army chief Gen. Manoj Pande, G20 Sherpa Amitabh Kant's erudite faceoff with the eloquently cutting Tamil Nadu finance minister Palanivel Thiaga Rajan, and a voluble tug of war between the BJP and Congress spokespersons, there was enough heat—but also plenty of light. A different kind of illumination awaited us as Harvard political philosopher Michael Sandel spoke about how elites have endangered democracy, Microsoft president and vice-chairman Brad Smith hinted at ChatGPT's coming competition with Google, and Harvard geneticist David Sinclair told us how death can be defied or at least postponed. Staying young was easy, with film luminati like Ram Charan of 'Naatu Naatu' fame and the upcoming Janhvi Kapoor with fashionista Malaika Arora lighting up the stage. Then there was cricket icon Sachin Tendulkar, who displayed his incredible memory, knowing exactly how he got out in every international match he played.

This issue brings you exciting snapshots, in words and images, of a live event. Democracy is India's biggest asset, and we must nurture it. That's why we have always considered the Conclave a mini ritual of democracy—a festival of ideas.



(Aroon Purie)